

ICS Activation Checklist — Hot Air Balloon Incidents

Printable checklist for a hard landing, in-flight emergency, or ground crew incident during a balloon safari.

Time	Step	Actions	Lead / support	Confirmations
0–1 min	Step 1 — Alert	- The pilot radios the balloon operator's ground crew as soon as an in-flight problem or hard landing occurs, giving location, guest numbers, and injuries if known. - The ground crew or lodge duty manager radios the Incident Commander: "Code Balloon — [location if known] — [number of guests]." - Note the balloon's last known position, direction of travel, and estimated landing area.	Balloon Pilot / Ground Crew / Duty Manager	☐ Location & guest count relayed ☐ IC alerted
1–3 min	Step 2 — Activate ICS	- IC starts the team and assigns OC, LC, Medic, Responders. - EC logs the time and known details; IC notifies the balloon operator's head office and Head Office.	IC / EC	☐ ICT activated, roles assigned ☐ HO & balloon operator notified
3–10 min	Step 3 — Reach the site	- The balloon operator's chase vehicles are usually first on scene — OC coordinates with them; lodge vehicles go only if requested or closer. - LC prepares a vehicle with first aid kit, stretcher, and water, and gets exact GPS coordinates before departure. - Do not approach the balloon or basket until the pilot confirms it is safe — burner and envelope can remain hazardous.	OC / LC / Ground Crew	☐ GPS coordinates confirmed ☐ Vehicle dispatched with medical kit
10–20 min	Step 4 — Medical assessment	- Medic checks every guest and crew member for injury, even if no one reports pain — hard landings can cause spinal or internal injuries that aren't immediately obvious. - If seriously injured, follow the Medical Emergencies checklist for evacuation and contact AMREF/Flying Doctors immediately.	Medic / Balloon Pilot / Ground Crew	☐ All guests & crew checked ☐ Evacuation initiated if required
20–60 min	Step 5 — Guest care & transport	- For uninjured guests, arrange transport back to the property; offer to contact family or their tour operator if they'd like reassurance sent. - The park or aviation authority may need to be informed, depending on severity — IC confirms with the balloon operator.	OC / LC / IC	☐ Guests transported · families/operator contacted if requested ☐ Authorities informed if required
Within 24 hrs	Step 6 — Debrief & reporting	- IC debriefs with the balloon operator and property team within 2 hours. - EC submits the Balloon Incident Report to Head Office within 24 hours and coordinates with the balloon operator's own incident reporting.	IC / EC	☐ Debrief done · report submitted